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In memory of Nellie Y. McKay

Cesaire's speech "Culture and Colonization," Baldwin's question brought nuance to this heady occasion. Partly answering his own question, Baldwin suggested, "whether they liked it or not," all those present, representing former (and some still), colonized nations, were "related to Europe, stained by European visions and standards . . . and their relation to themselves . . . and to their past had changed."

The very next year, in 1957, Baldwin would return to the United States, bringing the anti-colonial energies abroad to struggle for black liberation at home. This was a moment when many writers and intellectuals sought to establish the intricate connections between anti-colonialism and the movements for black civil rights for social and economic justice. That the U.S. civil rights movement gathered momentum at the same time that Ghana was about to achieve formal independence was an encouraging sign, but if, as Roi Ottley had proclaimed, blacks in the United States were "feeling a great resurgence of racial kinship to other colored people of the world," there remained pressing domestic questions to be addressed, chief among them, those concerning the viability of integration at a moment when many had begun to question whether a racially integrated America was possible.

Such questions grew louder and more insistent throughout the 1960s, voiced even by the formerly most vocal defenders of integrationism, including writer–activist James Baldwin. Returning to his signature rhetoric of apocalypse, Baldwin began to ask why any black American would want to be integrated into a burning house. Or as he put the matter to his biographer, Fern Eckman: "I don't want to be fitted into this society . . . I would rather be *dead*. In fact, there's no difference between being fitted into this society and *dying*."

PROPHETS OF A NEW DAY

Making similar use of apocalyptic imagery, black writers emerging in the waning days of the 1950s, served notice that yet another era in black letters was struggling to be born. The apocalypse they heralded was indeed the realization of Old Testament prophecy, which James Baldwin borrowed in titling his volume of essays *The Fire Next Time*. In the famous words of one of their idols, Malcolm X, whom they anointed the "fire prophet," these writers would force social revolution "by any means necessary." To borrow the title of Margaret Walker's volume of verse, these writers would come to be called the "prophets of a new day." One such self-styled prophet was Amiri Baraka (LeRoi Jones), whose signature poem, "Black Art," from his volume *Black Magic Poetry,* set much of the pace, form, and violent tone of the "new" black literature of the 1960s.

> We want "poems that kill."
> Assassin poems, Poems that shoot
> guns. Poems that wrestle cops into alleys
> and take their weapons leaving them dead
> with tongues pulled out and sent to Ireland.

Baraka's desire for "killing poems" hearkened back to Richard Wright's desire for "words as weapons," for art in the service of a struggle for human liberation. While some writers of the previous generation resisted the aesthetics and ideology of this Black Arts vanguard, others, notably Margaret Walker

and Gwendolyn Brooks, sought common cause with this younger generation. Brooks participated in poetry workshops with the Blackstone Rangers, a Chicago youth gang, and endeavored to take her poetry into the forgotten corners of African America: taverns, street corners, and prison cells.

The spirit of the times was reflected in the titles of books, magazines, and anthologies—*Black Feeling, Black Talk, Black Judgment, Black Fire, The Black Poets, The Black Aesthetic, Black World, Black Magic*—which rolled ferverishly off the presses, some newly established by blacks themselves. In keeping with this literary self-determination for blacks, Brooks severed ties with the New York publishing establishment and began to publish her work with the black-run Broadside Press. From this period came several volumes, including *In the Mecca* (1968), *Riot* (1969), *Family Pictures* (1970), and *The Near-Johannesburg Boy, and Other Poems* (1986).

Because black writers of the 1940–69 generation had earned their stripes, so to speak, in the American market of letters and had garnered a considerable degree of public success and recognition, it could be said that they opened a frontier on the future that the Harlem Renaissance generation had only dimly perceived. Though it would be a mistake to propose an evolutionary narrative of progress in which every round of writers gets "higher and higher," it seems plausible to argue that the 1940s to 1960s brought forth the first full crop of African American writers. Unlike at least most of their Harlem Renaissance predecessors, the writers of this period were bolder, more militant. With this generation of writers, black readers in particular were summoned to confront new literary realities, a bracing new tenor of change, whose echoes we occasionally hear as far away from its source as David Bradley's *Chaneysville Incident* (1981). This 1940–60 generation offers quite likely our most powerful cluster of texts and propositions in the post–World War II period.

MELVIN B. TOLSON

1898?–1966

If this anthology does nothing more than recover the works of Melvin B. Tolson to a wider audience, that alone will justify its existence. Reading Tolson allows one to explore modernist poetics from an African American cultural stance. Like Ralph Ellison and Gwendolyn Brooks, Tolson grew up on an American frontier; like Langston Hughes, he witnessed the later stages of the civil rights movement; and like modernist practitioners before him, he exploited poetic traditions.

Born February 6, in either 1898 or 1900, in Moberly, Missouri, to the Reverend Alonzo Tolson and Lera Hurt Tolson, Melvin was raised in a Methodist Episcopal household, with a father who had taught himself classical languages. As the reverend took different churches, the Tolsons moved around a circuit of small midwestern towns. It was in the local newspaper of Oskaloosa, Iowa, that Tolson, fourteen years old, published his first poem, on the sinking of the *Titanic*. Tolson moved with his family in 1916 to Kansas City, Missouri, where he was elected senior class poet. He spent one year at Fisk University but transferred the next to Lincoln University in

Lincoln, Pennsylvania; there he acquired impressive skills in debating and public speaking and met his future wife, Ruth Southall. They were married on January 29, 1922, and a year and a half later, Tolson graduated with a bachelor's degree. Shortly thereafter, Melvin B. Tolson, Jr. was born, the first of their four children.

Throughout the 1920s, Tolson taught at Wiley College in Marshall, Texas, where he coached the debating team and published adventure stories in the Wiley *Wild Cat*. With the advent of the Depression, he moved his family to his parents' home in Kansas City, and during a 1931–32 sabbatical from Wiley, he enrolled in a master's program in comparative literature at Columbia University in New York City, producing a thesis on the Harlem Renaissance. During that year, Tolson began writing his first book of poems, *Gallery of Harlem Portraits*, which was not published until 1965. Still, throughout the 1930s, poems from the volume appeared in *Arts Quarterly*, *Modern Monthly*, and *Modern Quarterly*. In New York, Tolson met important figures such as literary critic and editor V. F. Calverton, who described him in *Current History* as "a bright vivid writer who attains his best effects by understatement rather than overstatement, and who catches in a line or a stanza what most of his contemporaries have failed to capture in pages or volumes."

Tolson's fearless attitude toward controversy and his spirited defense of his religious and social views drew not only fire but also an invitation to publish in the *Pittsburgh Courier*. From 1937 to 1944 he wrote a weekly column, "Caviar and Cabbages," for the *Washington Tribune*. In the column, whose topics ranged from national politics to popular culture, Tolson attacked the class pretensions and lack of racial pride of the black middle class. His poem "Dark Symphony" (printed here) won first place in a 1939 national poetry contest sponsored by Chicago's American Negro Exposition. The poem chronicles the African American struggle from slavery to the emergence of the New Negro and the "black men" of Tolson's "day" who are inspired by their history to "advance" along "[w]ith the Peoples of the World." "Dark Symphony" moves through six sections, each titled with an Italian musical phrase framing the stanzas that follow. "I. Allegro Moderato," presents Crispus Attucks as an American hero against a backdrop of slave auctions and the specter of racial violence. Transitioning to "Lento Grave," a description of sorrowful slave songs, Tolson marks the tradition of music in which his symphony resides and the painful African American slave past denied in his contemporary moment. Set to a European classical tempo, slave voices evoke a "centuries-old pathos" that extends the pain of slavery beyond the physical and temporal bounds of antebellum America, firmly taking their place on the world stage. Evoking the plight of poor whites in *The Grapes of Wrath*, examples of treason in Italy, and German attacks against Poland, "Dark Symphony" refutes black stereotypes, reminding Tolson's readers that poverty, treachery, and violence belong not only to Richard Wright's Bigger Thomas but to people throughout the world. Ultimately, an argument for black human perseverance in a conflictual world, "Dark Symphony" returns to the heroism and optimism with which it began, anticipating a new American revolution of black progress, its soldiers marching in step with their global peers.

When the *Atlantic Monthly* published "Dark Symphony" in 1941, the magazine's editor at the time, Mary Lou Chamberlain, so admired it that upon moving to Dodd, Mead and Company, she urged Tolson to produce a volume for her to publish. *Rendezvous with America*, which includes the poem that so impressed Mead, was the result, and the book quickly saw three editions, from 1944 on. Tolson left Wiley College in 1947 for Langston University in Langston, Oklahoma; that same year he was named poet laureate of the West African nation of Liberia by its president, William S. V. Tubman, the son of Harriet Tubman. Perhaps the poet's most ambitious work, *Libretto for the Republic of Liberia* was commissioned that year; he completed it in 1953 for the 1956 Liberian centennial. Tolson was subsequently admitted to the Liberian Knighthood of the Order of the Star of Africa.

While the 1950s and 1960s would bring Tolson increasing successes—among them, *Poetry*'s Bess Hokin Prize for his 1951 poem "E. & O.E.," an honorary doctorate from Lincoln University in 1965, and a chair in the humanities at the Tuskegee Institute—none of these honors, perhaps, generated more excitement for Tolson

than his being elected mayor of the town of Langston for four consecutive terms, beginning in 1951. But as Tolson's visibility grew, his health declined. In 1966 he died of abdominal cancer.

Dark Symphony

I. Allegro Moderato[1]

Black Crispus Attucks[2] taught
Us how to die
Before white Patrick Henry's[3] bugle breath
Uttered the vertical
Transmitting cry: 5
"Yea, give me liberty or give me death."

Waifs of the auction block,
Men black and strong
The juggernauts of despotism withstood,
Loin-girt with faith that worms 10
Equate the wrong
And dust is purged to create brotherhood.

No Banquo's[4] ghost can rise
Against us now,
Aver we hobnailed Man beneath the brute, 15
Squeezed down the thorns of greed
On Labor's brow,
Garroted lands and carted off the loot.

II. Lento Grave[5]

The centuries-old pathos in our voices
Saddens the great white world, 20
And the wizardry of our dusky rhythms
Conjures up shadow-shapes of ante-bellum years:

Black slaves singing *One More River to Cross*
In the torture tombs of slave-ships,
Black slaves singing *Steal Away to Jesus* 25
In jungle swamps,
Black slaves singing *The Crucifixion*
In slave-pens at midnight,
Black slaves singing *Swing Low, Sweet Chariot*
In cabins of death, 30
Black slaves singing *Go Down, Moses*
In the canebrakes of the Southern Pharaohs.

1. Moderately lively (Italian). This and the other section titles are directions for the performance of music.
2. An escaped slave who was killed by the British in the Boston Massacre, March 5, 1770, a
3. Virginia-born patriot (1736–1799) whose oratorical skills fueled the American Revolution.
4. In Shakespeare's *Macbeth*, the murdered lord whose ghost haunts the guilty Macbeth.
5. Slowly and solemnly (Italian).

III. Andante Sostenuto[6]

They tell us to forget
The Golgotha[7] we tread . . .
We who are scourged with hate,
A price upon our head.
They who have shackled us
Require of us a song,
They who have wasted us
Bid us condone the wrong.

They tell us to forget
Democracy is spurned.
They tell us to forget
The Bill of Rights is burned.
Three hundred years we slaved,
We slave and suffer yet:
Though flesh and bone rebel,
They tell us to forget!

Oh, how can we forget
Our human rights denied?
Oh, how can we forget
Our manhood crucified?
When Justice is profaned
And plea with curse is met,
When Freedom's gates are barred,
Oh, how can we forget?

IV. Tempo Primo[8]

The New Negro strides upon the continent
In seven-league boots . . .
The New Negro
Who sprang from the vigor-stout loins
Of Nat Turner,[9] gallows-martyr for Freedom,
Of Joseph Cinquez,[1] Black Moses of the Amistad Mutiny,
Of Frederick Douglass,[2] oracle of the Catholic Man,
Of Sojourner Truth,[3] eye and ear of Lincoln's legions,
Of Harriet Tubman,[4] Saint Bernard of the Underground Railroad.

The New Negro
Breaks the icons of his detractors,
Wipes out the conspiracy of silence,
Speaks to *his* America:
"My history-moulding ancestors

6. Moderately slowly and sustained (Italian).
7. Or the hill of Calvary, where Jesus was crucified.
8. In the time of the opening movement (Italian).
9. Led his fellow slaves in a revolt against his master and other local whites (1800–1831).
1. Or Cinqué, led an 1839 mutiny on board *The Amistad*, a slave ship.
2. African American abolitionist (1817–1895), writer, and orator.
3. African American abolitionist and religious orator (ca. 1797–1883).
4. An escaped slave (ca. 1820–1913) who helped hundreds of other slaves escape to freedom in the North.

Planted the first crops of wheat on these shores,
Built ships to conquer the seven seas,
Erected the Cotton Empire,
Flung railroads across a hemisphere,
Disemboweled the earth's iron and coal,

Tunneled the mountains and bridged rivers,
Harvested the grain and hewed forests,
Sentineled the Thirteen Colonies,
Unfurled Old Glory at the North Pole,[5]
Fought a hundred battles for the Republic."

The New Negro:
His giant hands fling murals upon high chambers,
His drama teaches a world to laugh and weep,
His music leads continents captive,
His voice thunders the Brotherhood of Labor,
His science creates seven wonders,
His Republic of Letters challenges the Negro-baiters.

The New Negro,
Hard-muscled, Fascist-hating, Democracy-ensouled,
Strides in seven-league boots
Along the Highway of Today
Toward the Promised Land of Tomorrow!

V. Larghetto[6]

None in the Land can say
To us black men Today:
You send the tractors on their bloody path,
And create Okies for *The Grapes of Wrath*.[7]
You breed the slum that breeds a *Native Son*[8]
To damn the good earth Pilgrim Fathers won.

None in the Land can say
To us black men Today:
You dupe the poor with rags-to-riches tales,
And leave the workers empty dinner pails.
You stuff the ballot box, and honest men
Are muzzled by your demagogic din.

None in the Land can say
To us black men Today:
You smash stock markets with your coined blitzkriegs,[9]
And make a hundred million guinea pigs.

5. Reference to Matthew Henson (1866–1955), African American explorer and co-discoverer, with Robert Peary, of the North Pole.
6. Somewhat slowly (Italian).
7. John Steinbeck's 1939 novel is about an Oklahoma family's trek westward looking for farmwork.
8. Richard Wright's 1940 novel about Bigger Thomas, a young African American living in the northern ghettos, specifically Chicago.
9. Lightning wars (German, literal trans.); sudden attacks made by Germany against Poland and France during World War II.

You counterfeit our Christianity,
And bring contempt upon Democracy.

None in the Land can say
To us black men Today:
You prowl when citizens are fast asleep,
And hatch Fifth Column[1] plots to blast the deep
Foundations of the State and leave the Land
A vast Sahara with a Fascist brand.

VI. Tempo di Marcia[2]

Out of abysses of Illiteracy,
Through labyrinths of Lies,
Across waste lands of Disease . . .
We advance!

Out of dead-ends of Poverty,
Through wildernesses of Superstition,
Across barricades of Jim Crowism[3] . . .
We advance!

With the Peoples of the World . . .
We advance!

1944

The Birth of John Henry[1]

The night John Henry is born an ax
of lightning splits the sky,
and a hammer of thunder pounds the earth,
and the eagles and panthers cry!

John Henry—he says to his Ma and Pa:
"Get a gallon of barleycorn.[2]
I want to start right, like a he-man child,
the night that I am born!"

Says: "I want some ham hocks, ribs, and jowls,
a pot of cabbage and greens;
some hoecakes,[3] jam, and buttermilk,
a platter of pork and beans!"

1. Franco (fascist) sympathizers in Madrid during the Spanish Civil War (1936–39); more generally, a group who acts traitorously out of secret sympathy with an enemy of their country.
2. In march time (Italian).
3. Legal system that promoted racial segregation; first enacted by southern legislatures in 1865 [illegible] transportation.

1. A legendary figure from African American ballads and folklore. In the story, John Henry competed with a steam-powered drill to drive railroad spikes; he won the contest but died from exhaustion.
2. Whiskey made from barley.

John Henry's Ma—she wrings her hands,
and his Pa—he scratches his head.
John Henry—he curses in giraffe-tall words,
flops over, and kicks down the bed.

He's burning mad, like a bear on fire—
so he tears to the riverside.
As he stoops to drink, Old Man River gets scared
and runs upstream to hide!

Some say he was born in Georgia—O Lord!
Some say in Alabam.
But it's writ on the rock at the Big Bend Tunnel:
"Lousyana was my home. So scram!"

1965

Satchmo[1]

King Oliver[2] of New Orleans
has kicked the bucket, but he left behind
old Satchmo with his red-hot horn
to syncopate the heart and mind.
The honky-tonks in Storyville
have turned to ashes, have turned to dust,
but old Satchmo is still around
like Uncle Sam's IN GOD WE TRUST.

Where, oh, where is Bessie Smith[3]
with her heart as big as the blues of truth?
Where, oh, where is Mister Jelly Roll[4]
with his Cadillac and diamond tooth?
Where, oh, where is Papa Handy[5]
with his blue notes a-dragging from bar to bar?
Where, oh, where is bulletproof Leadbelly[6]
with his tall tales and 12-string guitar?

1965

1. The title of American jazz musician Louis Armstrong's (1901–1971) autobiography.
2. New Orleans–born bandleader (1885–1938), whose King Oliver Creole Band was considered the greatest jazz band of its day. Armstrong stated that Oliver was his true idol.
3. American blues singer (1894–1937), known as the Empress of the Blues.
American jazz pianist.
5. William Christopher Handy (1873–1958), American composer known as the Father of the Blues.
6. Nickname for American blues singer Hudson William Ledbetter (1885–1949). Master of the guitar, Ledbetter was one of the most prolific performers of the blues genre.